Startup breakdown

$3.1B

Uber paid it to buy its rival instead of beating it

Careem, 2019.

The biggest tech deal in the region at the time.



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It started boring

Dubai, 2012: booking cars for company employees. Not a "change the world" app. Corporate clients who paid from early on.



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They did things Uber wasn't looking at

Cash payments, because many people in the region had no card.

And the driver was a "captain", not a number in a system.



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The difference wasn't money

Uber was much bigger and richer.

Careem understood the market from the inside.



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The deal

$1.4B in cash and $1.7B in notes

Uber kept Careem running as a separate brand and app. It bought the local knowledge, not just the customers.



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In markets like Saudi Arabia, Egypt and Pakistan

That knowledge was built into the product itself: how people pay, the language, the relationship with the captain.



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Save this

What the giant is too lazy to do

1. A local payment method
2. The customer's language and dialect
3. Local regulation, like ZATCA
4. Local sales channels and relationships



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I'm Mohammed. I build products, and the machine that sells them, from Riyadh.

Save this, and tell me in the comments:
what do the big players ignore in your market?



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